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Joel

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Joel

A. Summary and Overview.

1. The book of Joel was written by the prophet Joel whose name means “Yawheh is God”, as identified in verse 1:1. Joel is one of the minor prophets, not because of insignificance, but due to length. It has only three chapters. It is believed by some, including Jewish tradition, that the prophet wrote this book sometime in the 835 to 800 BC timeframe to the Northern Kingdom, Israel. But there is disagreement, as some scholars believe it was written to the Southern Kingdom Judah, due to references to Judah and Jerusalem in chapter 3. Joel does not give us specifics which could make a better determination. Regardless, Joel’s message of a coming “day of the Lord” (1:15) is prophetic, and applies in the near-term future of Israel and Judah as well as end times events. Joel uses the term “the day of the Lord” for a total of five times throughout the book. The day of the Lord represents a day of judgement, when God’s wrath is poured out on the unrepentant nation due to its sin, idolatry and departure from Him. It is an example of near-far fulfillment of prophecy, as it relates to the near prophetic application to Israel and Judah, as well as to the nations at the end times.

B. Chapter 1. The setting depicts a vast plague of locusts, which destroys everything, stripping fields of grain, gardens and even the bark off of trees. The locusts are likened metaphorically to a vast army that will eventually destroy the land. This occurred during the Assyrian conquest of Israel, which began about 740 BC and culminated in the fall of Israel’s capital, Samaria, in 722 BC. Joel calls the elders to a fast: “Consecrate a fast; call a solemn assembly. Gather the elders and all the inhabitants of the land to the house of the LORD your God, and cry out to the LORD” (VS. 1:14).

C. Chapter 2.

1. The chapter continues the analogy of the locusts as a vast conquering army which could be the Assyrians, as previously mentioned, or the Babylonians who conquered Jerusalem in 586 BC. There is a plea to return to the Lord: “Yet even now,” declares the LORD, ‘return to me with all your heart, with fasting, with weeping, and with mourning; and rend your hearts and not your garments.’ Return to the LORD your God, for he is gracious and merciful, slow to anger,

and abounding in steadfast love; and he relents over disaster. Who knows whether he will not turn and relent, and leave a blessing behind him a grain offering and a drink offering for the LORD your God?" (Vs. 2:12-14). What Joel is saying is that true repentance of the heart could very well turn away the wrath of God and "the day of the Lord".

2. There is the promise of the outpouring of the Holy Spirit: "And it shall come to pass afterward, that I will pour out my Spirit on all flesh; your sons and your daughters shall prophesy, your old men shall dream dreams, and your young men shall see visions" (Vs.2:28). The Apostle Peter references this passage in Acts 2:17) on the day of Pentecost.

D. Chapter 3.

1. The chapter opens with a direct reference to end times: "For behold, in those days and at that time, when I restore the fortunes of Judah and Jerusalem, I will gather all the nations and bring them down to the Valley of Jehoshaphat. And I will enter into judgment with them there, on behalf of my people and my heritage Israel, because they have scattered them among the nations and have divided up my land" (Vs.3:1-2). It also references the winepress of God's wrath (3:13) and supernatural events such as the darkening of sun and moon and stars (Vs. 3:14b-15).
2. The book concludes with a vision of the future restoration of Israel and Judah: "So you shall know that I am the LORD your God, who dwells in Zion, my holy mountain. And Jerusalem shall be holy, and strangers shall never again pass through it. 'And in that day the mountains shall drip sweet wine, and the hills shall flow with milk, and all the streambeds of Judah shall flow with water; and a fountain shall come forth from the house of the LORD and water the Valley of Shittim'" (Vs, 3:17-18).

E. Discussion Questions, Application and Passing it on.

1. It was customary in biblical times for those suffering great anguish to rend, or tear, their garments as a sign of their distress. Joel writes in 2:13 to "rend your hearts and not your garments". What do you think the Holy Spirit is telling us through the prophet Joel?
2. How could you use the term "the day of the Lord" in your personal evangelism?
3. How does the book of Joel give us hope for the future?

This Old Testament survey was provided by Joshua Nations (JoshuaNations.org)

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In Christ,

The JesusOnline Ministries Team

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